

RESEARCH PAPER

Playing the Future

Speculative Videogames as Foresight
for Post-Gender Femininities

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*"Does a speculative gender premise change the rules that
organize gender — or merely place familiar arrangements
inside unfamiliar science-fictional forms?"*

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FORESIGHT · VIDEOGAMES · CRITICAL FEMININITIES

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ABSTRACT

Commercial videogames routinely ask large audiences to inhabit synthetic bodies, alien societies, and configurable civilizations, yet their value as foresight artifacts is rarely examined alongside their gender politics. This chapter proposes the Translation Test, a method derived from Margaret Boden's distinction between combinational, exploratory, and transformational creativity. The test asks whether a speculative gender premise changes the rules that organize gender across six dimensions — ontology, embodiment, language, social role, systemic consequence, and player agency — or merely places familiar arrangements inside unfamiliar science-fictional forms. Applied to *NieR: Automata*, *Mass Effect*, and *Stellaris*, the method finds uneven transformation: biological premises change more readily than the aesthetic, linguistic, and institutional conventions through which femininity remains legible. The chapter argues that commercial games can function as informal foresight artifacts when their rules make alternative arrangements encounterable and consequential, while reserving claims about actual foresight effects for reception research.

KEYWORDS videogames; foresight; speculative design; critical femininities; femme theory; gender; creativity

Introduction

Videogames occupy an awkward position in conversations about the future. Futures studies has a substantial tradition of games, simulations, scenario exercises, and experiential methods designed explicitly to expand participants' capacity to consider alternatives (Sweeney 2017; Candy and Dunagan 2017; Vervoort 2019). What has received less sustained attention is the reverse question: what happens when commercial games not built as foresight interventions nevertheless place millions of players inside speculative worlds and require them to operate there? A science-fiction game may ask players to navigate a society without biological sex, form relationships with a mono-gendered alien species, or design a civilization in which gender is optional. Such games do not merely describe future possibilities. They make some of those possibilities playable, repeatable, and materially consequential within a rule-bound system.

Gender scholarship on games, meanwhile, has usually approached such worlds through representation: whether a character is sexualized, whether a narrative reproduces stereotypes, or whether a game offers progressive or regressive images of women and gender minorities. Those questions remain important, but they do not fully capture what speculative games claim to do. The more specific question pursued here is whether their imagined gender arrangements constitute genuinely different conceptual systems or whether science-fictional novelty disguises familiar structures. If a synthetic body, alien physiology, or procedurally generated species is removed as explanatory apparatus and the underlying gender configuration is restated in ordinary language, does a new set of rules remain? Or does the future collapse back into the present it appeared to exceed?

This chapter treats three games — *NieR: Automata*, *Mass Effect*, and *Stellaris* — as informal foresight artifacts and develops a Translation Test for answering that question. The test adapts Margaret Boden's (2004) distinction between combinational, exploratory, and transformational creativity. Its purpose is not to score games as progressive or regressive, nor to require femininity to disappear from post-gender futures. It asks where novelty actually resides: in the body, in the language, in the social role, in institutions, in mechanics, or in the player's capacity to alter the schema itself. That distinction matters because speculative fiction can redesign biology radically while leaving the cultural rules attached to femininity almost untouched.

Critical Femininities scholarship provides the second theoretical axis. Here, femininity means a historically variable set of signs, practices, affects, roles, and valuations coded as feminine; it is not a synonym for women, female biology, or personal identity (Dahl 2012; Hoskin and Blair 2022). “Feminine-coded” therefore describes how a body, voice, title, role, or design is made culturally legible. “Post-gender” names a speculative condition in which binary gender or biological sex is declared absent, optional, reorganized, or no longer socially foundational. Hoskin’s (2017) concept of femmephobia is useful because devaluation and regulation of femininity can operate independently of female biology. The analysis does not assume that dresses, eroticism, motherhood, or feminine pronouns are inherently oppressive. Its concern is narrower: whether familiar feminine forms remain flexible and valued, or whether a speculative world reproduces a restricted grammar in which femininity is unusually aestheticized, sexualized, maternalized, or made socially legible through a narrow set of roles.

Videogames as Foresight Artifacts

The claim that games can contribute to foresight is not new. Futures practitioners have long used gaming and simulation to create participatory encounters with uncertainty, and the Journal of Futures Studies devoted a 2017 symposium to gaming futures. Sweeney (2017), writing from work with the United Nations, describes the growth of games and simulations within futures as a strategy for engagement and learning while also emphasizing the need for critical assessment of what such tools actually accomplish. Candy and Dunagan’s (2017) experiential futures similarly addresses the gap between abstract propositions about possible futures and situated encounters with them. Vervoort (2019) goes further by examining how developments in the commercial game sector might expand futures practice, highlighting games’ ability to combine dynamic systems, actor perspectives, narrative worlds, and interactivity. Commercial videogames therefore do not enter an empty methodological field. The gap is more precise: relatively little work treats already-existing entertainment games as mass-cultural speculative systems whose rules and representations can themselves be analyzed for the futures they make thinkable.

Dunne and Raby’s (2013) speculative design helps clarify why such analysis is worthwhile. A speculative object does not need to predict a future; it can make an alternative present tangible enough to debate. Games add operation to encounter. Their premises are often load-bearing: the player must act within a designed world, and the system responds according to rules that embody assumptions about what kinds of beings, relationships, institutions, and consequences can exist. This does not make every science-fiction game a foresight exercise. A game can depict a future while mechanically treating that future as scenery. Interactivity can intensify familiarity without producing reflection, and repeated exposure does not demonstrate learning.

For that reason, this chapter distinguishes a foresight artifact from a foresight effect. A work has foresight capacity when its design renders alternative arrangements encounterable, allows them to be explored through rules or choices, and makes their consequences available for discussion. A foresight effect would be a demonstrable change in what players can imagine, take seriously, or reason about after engagement with the work. Only reception research can establish the latter. The present analysis concerns the design side: whether a game supplies more than futuristic imagery by reorganizing the rules through which gender becomes intelligible. This narrower claim preserves what is distinctive about games without assuming that play automatically produces anticipatory learning.

Commercial scale adds a further reason to take these artifacts seriously without confusing popularity with efficacy. Purpose-built foresight games usually operate in bounded workshops with explicit facilitation, learning goals, and opportunities for reflection. Entertainment games circulate under very different conditions: players may approach them for mastery, narrative

pleasure, competition, identification, or habit rather than for anticipatory learning. Yet this lack of formal facilitation is precisely what makes them culturally interesting. They distribute speculative assumptions far beyond professional foresight settings and normalize certain future arrangements through repeated use. The analytical task is therefore not to grant commercial games the status of foresight methods, but to examine how their rule systems participate in broader future imaginaries. A game can matter to foresight because it makes a possible social order familiar, even when neither developer nor player describes the activity as foresight.

The Translation Test: A Method for Reading Speculative Femininity

Boden's (2004) taxonomy of creativity distinguishes three modes of novelty. Combinational creativity creates unfamiliar arrangements from familiar elements. Exploratory creativity searches an existing conceptual space more fully, discovering possibilities permitted by its rules even if they have rarely been used. Transformational creativity changes one or more of the generative rules that define the conceptual space, making possible outcomes that the previous system could not generate. This distinction is especially useful for speculative gender because science fiction often signals radical novelty through unfamiliar bodies while leaving the rules connecting bodies, roles, language, and social value intact.

The Translation Test operationalizes that distinction across six dimensions. It begins with a work's explicit speculative claim and then separates that claim from the observable design choices that implement it. The analyst translates the configuration into ordinary-language social terms without erasing the relevant consequences of context. The question is not whether a familiar sign remains visible, but whether the rule governing what that sign can mean, do, or authorize has changed. A feminine dress can therefore remain conventional at the level of embodiment while acquiring a different social meaning at the level of role or agency; conversely, unfamiliar terminology can conceal a familiar hierarchy.

TABLE 01 / TRANSLATION TEST DIMENSIONS AND DIAGNOSTIC QUESTIONS

Dimension	Diagnostic question
Ontology	What kinds of gendered or ungendered beings can exist, and what makes those categories possible?
Embodiment	How are bodies visually, materially, and mechanically coded, displayed, or differentiated?
Language	How are entities named, pronounced, titled, and made legible through categories?
Social role	What relationships, affects, occupations, and narrative positions can different gender configurations occupy?
Systemic consequence	Does gender reorganize kinship, reproduction, labor, authority, citizenship, diplomacy, conflict, or other institutions?
Player agency	Can players alter the underlying schema, or only choose values from categories the game has already defined?

In practice, each case follows five steps: identify the announced speculative departure; map its implementation across the six dimensions; translate each dimension into ordinary-language social relations; classify the novelty as combinational, exploratory, or transformational; and record a plausible alternative reading. The final step is important because translation is interpretive rather than mechanical. Context cannot simply be deleted: a familiar feminine form on a non-reproductive android may carry meanings unavailable to the same form on a human character. The test therefore removes the science-fictional rationale only to ask what work that rationale actually performs. Where meaning changes because context changes, the analysis should register transformation; where context merely supplies a futuristic explanation for an unchanged rule, it should not.

The unit of analysis is therefore a relation rather than an isolated sign. A breast, pronoun, title, romance option, or menu setting has little diagnostic force by itself. What matters is the rule linking that element to other possibilities: whether a body determines social role, whether a pronoun fixes ontology, whether reproduction structures citizenship, whether visual coding changes how agency is distributed, or whether a menu choice alters later simulation. Evidence should likewise be hierarchical. Primary game text, mechanics, interface behavior, and developer documentation establish what the artifact does; scholarly analysis helps position those observations; community discussions can identify points of friction but cannot stand in for representative reception. This hierarchy is particularly important for continuously updated games such as *Stellaris*, where interface details may change while the deeper design principle remains stable. The Translation Test is strongest when it records the version or textual evidence on which a classification rests rather than treating a game as a fixed object.

NieR: Automata — The Android Body and the Persistence of Design

NieR: Automata (PlatinumGames 2017) stages gender after biology with unusual explicitness. Its YoRHa protagonists are android combat units that do not reproduce, yet they are built as male-type and female-type models and inherit gendered forms from human culture. Production interviews reinforce the point that the distinction is designed rather than biologically necessary (Gematsu 2015). This makes the game a useful test case: if sexual reproduction is absent and embodiment is manufactured, gender can in principle become visibly contingent. The game also repeatedly places androids in emotional, intimate, and social relations that complicate the human categories they imitate.

At the level of narrative role, 2B and 9S rearrange familiar gendered traits. 2B, female-coded, is the more controlled and combat-oriented partner; 9S, male-coded, is more openly curious, emotionally expressive, and frequently vulnerable. Pascal, a masculine-coded machine lifeform, occupies a caring and pedagogical role within a village of childlike machines. Same-gender attachment among androids can appear without the narrative requiring a special ontological explanation. These choices matter, but the Translation Test requires care in classifying them. Reversing the conventional assignment of stoicism and vulnerability does not by itself transform the conceptual rules of gender. It is primarily combinational, and perhaps exploratory: familiar attributes are redistributed across familiar masculine and feminine positions. The stronger novelty lies elsewhere, in the game's sustained separation of gender coding from reproductive biology and in its willingness to let relational roles circulate independently of that biology.

Embodiment produces a different result. 2B's closely fitted black dress, exposed thighs, high boots, and damage mechanics that alter the costume are deliberate design choices, and production discussion explicitly linked her visual design to cosplay appeal (Gematsu 2015). Her mourning aesthetic, blindfold, militarized function, and visibly artificial body complicate any simple equation with a human pin-up character. Nevertheless, when the biological rationale is removed, much of the visual grammar remains continuous with conventional sexualized femininity in games. The post-biological premise does not substantially reorganize who is composed for viewing or how a female-coded body is made aesthetically legible. Here the novelty is combinational: an artificial body is coupled to an established feminine visual economy.

Gameplay strengthens the split rather than resolving it. Combat positions 2B as the primary embodied agent for much of the opening route: competence is enacted, not merely stated. Yet the player's moment-to-moment control does not make gender itself a manipulable system. The player cannot redesign YoRHa's typing schema, make embodiment socially consequential in a different way, or test an alternative institution of gender. The game therefore transforms the ontological relation between sexed biology and gender coding more strongly than it transforms the aesthetic or systemic organization of gender. That distinction is more defensible under Boden's terms than calling the role reversal itself transformational. NieR's achievement is not that it invents unfamiliar masculine and feminine traits, but that it creates a world where gendered form persists after its assumed biological foundation has disappeared — making the persistence itself available for scrutiny.

The camera and costume systems are important here because they turn embodiment into something the player repeatedly encounters through play rather than a static character illustration. The body is moved, framed, damaged, repaired, and viewed across long stretches of combat and traversal. That repetition gives aesthetic coding procedural weight even when it does not affect the fictional institutions of YoRHa. The Translation Test therefore resists separating representation and mechanics too cleanly: a visual convention can become systemic when the game repeatedly operationalizes it through camera behavior, damage states, or player

incentives. In NieR, however, this proceduralization intensifies the visibility of feminine embodiment without giving the player comparable leverage over the gender schema itself.

Mass Effect's Asari — Post-Gender Worldbuilding and the Return of the Matriarch

Mass Effect's Asari (BioWare 2007–2017) move the problem from an individual artificial body to a species-wide social ontology. Asari reproduce through melding and can conceive with partners of any species or gender while producing Asari offspring. Human male/female categories do not map neatly onto their own self-description. This premise has already attracted substantial gender and posthuman analysis. Zekany (2016), for example, examines how human gender categories continue to frame nonhuman desire in the series, while Lucas (2018) focuses directly on Asari sexuality, feminine presentation, and the Maiden-Matron-Matriarch life stages. The contribution here is therefore not to rediscover that the Asari are coded as feminine. It is to use the Translation Test to locate where the species' announced departure from binary gender changes the rules and where it does not.

Ontology changes substantially. A species without a male reproductive category, capable of reproduction with partners outside its own species, is not simply a human binary with cosmetic variation. Mass Effect also invites the player to encounter this ontology through dialogue, romance possibilities, codex material, and recurring interactions rather than through a single exposition scene. Reproductive possibility and partner eligibility are therefore genuinely reorganized. At the same time, the representational system converts much of this ontological difference into highly familiar femininity. Asari are consistently voiced and pronounced as feminine in the English-language games; their bodies are rendered with conventionally feminine silhouettes and facial structures; and the player rarely receives a sustained competing mode of recognition. Any individual element might be explained as translation for human characters or audience legibility. Taken together, they make femininity the universalized surface through which monogender becomes intelligible.

The life-stage system is the sharpest example. Maiden, Matron, and Matriarch organize the Asari life course around youthful exploration, a reproductive or child-rearing middle period, and elder authority. Lucas (2018) has already noted the gendered and sexual implications of this sequence. The Translation Test shows why it matters structurally: the species' reproductive ontology is unusual, but its principal age categories remain tied to a recognizable feminine progression. The Matriarch is not merely an old Asari; the title itself translates authority through maternal vocabulary. This does not make motherhood or feminine elderhood intrinsically patriarchal. The issue is the narrowness and regularity of the mapping: a supposedly post-binary species becomes culturally legible through terms whose social meanings are saturated with human femininity.

Player agency complicates the verdict. Mass Effect lets players pursue relationships with Asari through different versions of Commander Shepard, which can normalize same-gender or cross-species intimacy without requiring the Asari to be slotted neatly into human heterosexual reproduction. Yet the player cannot meaningfully interrogate or reconfigure the species-level schema. Dialogue choices can express attitudes toward Asari individuals, but the social system itself remains authored and largely non-negotiable. The result is therefore mixed rather than a simple “costume” verdict. Reproductive ontology is transformational relative to the human binary assumed by the setting; partner eligibility is expanded; but language, embodiment, and life-course categorization translate much of that novelty back into universalized femininity. The case demonstrates the value of separating dimensions: calling the Asari merely an “all-female race” misses what their reproduction changes, while treating monogender as proof of post-gender worldbuilding overstates how far the representational and social rules move.

The role of dialogue is also revealing. Mass Effect gives the player substantial conversational agency, but most choices operate at the level of interpersonal stance rather than world-model revision. Shepard can accept, reject, flirt with, question, or judge particular Asari, yet cannot meaningfully test a different account of Asari gender within the setting. The codex and character conversations remain the authoritative infrastructure through which the species is explained. This is a useful reminder that branching dialogue is not automatically transformational agency. Choice matters for the Translation Test only when it changes the conceptual or institutional relations under examination, not simply when it changes tone, romance outcome, or local narrative state.

Stellaris — Gender as a Configurable Parameter

Stellaris (Paradox Development Studio 2016–present) shifts the problem again, from authored character and species lore to systemic configuration. Players create species by selecting biological, visual, ethical, political, and governmental parameters. Gender presentation operates through portraits, names, pronouns, and species-level settings whose interface has changed across versions (Paradox Interactive 2025). The crucial analytical question is not whether one particular character looks feminine, but what kinds of gender systems the simulation allows players to construct and what consequences those systems have once play begins.

On the surface, Stellaris appears closest to transformational authorship because gender can be declared absent or configured at species scale. The Translation Test, however, separates declaration from consequence. In the base game, gender settings have relatively little effect on kinship, labor, political authority, citizenship, diplomacy, warfare, reproduction, or economic organization. A civilization can be labeled genderless while institutions continue to function exactly as they would for a gendered species. This maximizes ontological configurability while minimizing social transformation. The game changes which labels and portraits can exist more readily than it changes the rules that organize society around those labels.

That distinction also clarifies player agency. A menu can offer many values while retaining a fixed schema. Selecting “one gender” or disabling gender distinctions is not the same creative act as defining a society in which gender structures inheritance, occupational specialization, reproduction, kinship, diplomatic status, or political office according to new rules. In Boden's terms, the player is mostly exploring a designer-defined conceptual space rather than transforming its generative structure. Community requests for additional genders, pronouns, and role-based systems, as well as modifications that extend presentation options, are useful here not as representative evidence of all players but as diagnostic evidence of where some highly engaged players experience the boundaries of the base schema (Steam Community 2022; Steam Community n.d.).

At the same time, Stellaris is the case that most clearly demonstrates why games matter to foresight. Species design is connected to a simulation that runs forward. Ethics, civics, traits, diplomacy, demography, and political choices can generate consequences over centuries of play. Gender is notable precisely because it participates so weakly in that otherwise dense causal system. The player can configure it, but usually cannot test what different gender institutions would do. This absence is analytically productive: it distinguishes representation from simulation. Stellaris grants formal authorship over gender presentation but little substantive authorship over gender as social structure. A future can therefore be very customizable while remaining conceptually conservative at the level of causal rules.

A stronger transformational implementation would not require the game to prescribe a single politics of gender. It could instead make gender one possible source of institutional variation: affecting inheritance, reproductive organization, leadership eligibility, family structure, demographic change, faction formation, or diplomatic interpretation, with different

combinations producing different consequences. Such a system would be difficult to design and could easily reproduce stereotypes, but that difficulty is analytically instructive. *Stellaris* already models numerous abstract traits by translating them into modifiers and event chains; gender remains comparatively insulated from those causal networks. The Translation Test therefore identifies not merely a missing representation option, but a missing counterfactual space: the player can declare a society different without being able to explore what that difference changes.

Discussion: Costume, Concept, and the Limits of Player Authorship

Read together, the cases reveal why a dimensional method is more useful than a single representational verdict. *NieR: Automata* transforms the relation between reproductive biology and gender coding while largely retaining conventional feminine embodiment; its role reversals are significant but mostly combinational rather than transformational. *Mass Effect* transforms reproductive ontology and partner possibility while translating much of a mono-gendered species through feminine language, bodies, and life stages already legible within human culture. *Stellaris* gives the player broad authority to declare a species gendered or genderless but leaves that declaration weakly connected to the institutions simulated elsewhere in the game. Each case therefore locates novelty in a different place, and none can be described adequately by asking only whether it contains “good” or “bad” representation.

The comparison supports a provisional hypothesis: speculative games may find it easier to detach femininity from biological necessity than to redesign the aesthetic and institutional conventions through which femininity becomes socially meaningful. Synthetic bodies can exist without reproduction; alien species can exceed binary reproductive categories; generated civilizations can remove gender labels. Yet once those futures must be rendered, named, narrated, and systematized, familiar conventions often return. This is not a claim that femininity itself is a residue of the present that a sufficiently advanced future should eliminate. Such a conclusion would reproduce the very devaluation of femininity that femme theory challenges. The issue is whether feminine forms are allowed multiplicity and new relations, or whether they remain unusually burdened with aesthetic legibility, sexual availability, maternal symbolism, and limited causal significance.

This distinction also helps avoid circularity in the use of ‘patriarchal femininity.’ A feminine-coded sign is not classified as patriarchal simply because it is familiar. The relevant evidence lies in constraints and relations. A dress is not a failed future because it is a dress; it becomes analytically significant when feminine embodiment is systematically more available for visual consumption than alternative embodiments, or when the surrounding world denies feminine-coded subjects comparable complexity and agency. Motherhood is not inherently conservative; it becomes constraining when maternal status is one of the principal routes through which authority or maturity becomes intelligible. Feminine pronouns are not oppressive by definition; they matter when an allegedly post-gender ontology is made almost exclusively readable through one inherited human category. The Translation Test therefore asks what the sign is permitted to do, not whether the sign is new.

The three cases also sharpen the distinction between configuration and concept formation. Contemporary games often market customization as authorship, but an abundance of selectable values does not necessarily widen the conceptual space. A player can create thousands of visually distinct species in *Stellaris* while remaining unable to specify a genuinely different gender institution. Conversely, a tightly authored work such as *NieR* may contain less explicit customization but more conceptual friction because its narrative repeatedly confronts the player with gendered forms that lack the biological foundations those forms conventionally

imply. Player freedom and conceptual novelty are therefore related but not interchangeable dimensions.

For foresight, this matters because an artifact's value does not depend only on how strange its future looks. Futures practice distinguishes between multiplying images of the future and expanding the rules by which alternatives can be conceived. Commercial games can contribute to the latter when mechanics expose assumptions, require choices among genuinely different arrangements, and return consequences that make those arrangements discussable. They can also demonstrate the opposite: how easily a radical premise is domesticated by conventional design grammars. In that sense, failure to transform can itself be foresight material. A game that imagines genderless civilizations but cannot imagine institutions altered by gender's absence reveals a boundary in the present-day imagination from which it was designed.

The method is also portable beyond these cases. The same distinction between premise and generative rule could be applied to synthetic humans in film, AI companions, virtual influencers, embodied robots, transhumanist fiction, or design prototypes. Its usefulness would not lie in deciding whether a future artifact is sufficiently radical, but in making the location of novelty explicit. An apparently conventional body may participate in transformed social relations; an unfamiliar body may leave those relations untouched. By forcing the analysis to say which rule changed, the Translation Test turns a broad intuition about old ideas in new costumes into a claim that can be challenged, compared, and refined across media.

Limitations and Future Directions

Three limitations bound these claims. First, translation remains interpretive. The six dimensions and five-step protocol make disagreement locatable, but they do not turn cultural analysis into measurement. Different analysts may reasonably disagree about whether a contextual change is strong enough to count as transformational, particularly in *NieR*, where artificial embodiment and conventional sexualization coexist. Future applications should therefore report alternative readings rather than treating classifications as self-evident.

Second, the corpus is purposive and small. The three games were chosen because they locate speculative gender at different levels — individual body, species ontology, and civilization-generation system — not because they represent videogames as a whole. The recurring pattern identified here should therefore be treated as a hypothesis for wider testing. A larger corpus should include independent games, more genres, production contexts beyond Japan and North America, and works by trans, non-binary, queer, and femme creators. Such expansion is especially important because the visual and social grammars associated with femininity are culturally variable.

The comparative logic also has a consequence for generalization. These cases differ not only in national production context but in genre, authorship structure, and the level at which gender enters play. *NieR* is a tightly authored action role-playing game, *Mass Effect* combines authored worldbuilding with branching role-play, and *Stellaris* is a grand-strategy simulation centered on procedural systems. Similar findings across them are therefore suggestive, but differences may arise from genre conventions as much as from gender ideology. A broader study should treat genre and production history as explanatory variables rather than assuming that all speculative games solve design problems in the same way.

Third, this chapter analyzes designed texts and systems rather than player outcomes. The foresight framing ultimately raises an empirical question: does inhabiting these worlds expand what players can imagine or take seriously? A critic may classify a design as combinational while a player experiences it as genuinely horizon-expanding; the reverse is also possible. Interviews, player diaries, community-text analysis, or pre/post elicitation methods used in experiential futures could test whether the Translation Test's design-side classifications correlate with changes in anticipatory imagination. Such research would also help distinguish familiarity, identification,

reflection, and genuine conceptual expansion rather than treating them as equivalent effects of immersion.

Conclusion

Commercial videogames are not substitutes for structured foresight methods, but neither are they merely futuristic stories with buttons. They are large-scale speculative systems in which possible worlds are encountered through repeated action. The Translation Test offers one way to evaluate how far those systems move beyond the present. Derived from Boden's account of creativity, it asks whether speculative gender changes the rules governing ontology, embodiment, language, social role, systemic consequence, and player agency, or merely recombines familiar elements under a new fictional rationale.

Applied to three contrasting games, the test produces differentiated results. *NieR: Automata* most clearly transforms the relation between biology and gender while retaining a conventional visual economy around its female-coded protagonist; its role reversals redistribute familiar traits rather than fully transforming the gender schema. *Mass Effect's* Asari change reproductive ontology and partner possibility but translate much of monogender through universalized femininity and a familiar life-course grammar. *Stellaris* permits gender configuration at species scale while leaving most simulated institutions untouched, exposing the difference between selecting a parameter and authoring a new social rule. Across the cases, biological imagination repeatedly outruns social imagination.

The argument is therefore not that speculative femininity should become unrecognizable, nor that familiar feminine forms are evidence of failure. A future becomes conceptually new when the relations that organize those forms change: what they authorize, how they are valued, which institutions they shape, and what kinds of lives they make possible. That is also where videogames have distinctive unrealized potential as foresight artifacts. Their systems can do more than costume the future. They can let players encounter new generative rules and discover what follows when those rules are allowed to matter. ## References

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